GCSE BUSINESS

First Lesson Back

A ready-to-run 60-minute opening lesson for the start of GCSE Business, plus a baseline diagnostic. Year 10 course opener.

GCSE / IGCSE Business · AQA 8132 · Edexcel 1BS0 · Cambridge 0450 · Print-friendly · B&W

What's inside

- A 60-minute teacher run sheet you can teach straight from the print-out
- A Gymshark do-now and a whole-class risk debate built on the M&S 2025 cyber-attack
- A pair task: what really makes an entrepreneur?
- A 10-question baseline diagnostic to see what students walk in knowing
- Full teacher answers, discussion pointers and an exit ticket

Real UK companies. No prep needed beyond printing. Free to use and share with your department.

Who this is for

Year 10 students starting GCSE Business — and it works just as well as an IGCSE course opener or a Year 11 September re-starter. Everything is on the student pages, so a non-specialist or cover teacher can run it too.

At a glance

60 minutes — full run sheet with timings on page 2 · **No prep** — print and teach · **4 real UK companies** — Gymshark, M&S, Greggs and Aldi · **Baseline diagnostic** — 10 questions with teacher answer guidance · **Exit ticket** — ready-made plenary.

The one argument this lesson plants

Gymshark sells £646m a year and keeps £7m as profit. Ask a class whether that's a triumph or a warning sign and you get both answers, defended with feeling. That disagreement — revenue vs profit, growth vs safety — is the argument the whole GCSE course keeps returning to. This lesson starts it on day one.

Teacher run sheet — 60 minutes

Everything below is on the student pages that follow. You can teach this straight from the print-out. Timings are a guide — the Gymshark hook and the risk debate are the parts worth protecting.

Time	Phase	What happens
0–8 min	**Do-Now (p.3)**	Students read the Gymshark story and answer 3 questions solo, then compare in pairs.
8–20 min	**Hook discussion**	Whole-class: was Ben Francis lucky or good? Draw out enterprise, risk, opportunity.
20–35 min	**Core: risk & reward (p.4)**	Key terms, then the M&S cyber-attack case — who carries the risk, and who pays for it?
35–48 min	**Founder match task (p.5)**	Pair task: match enterprise traits to real businesses, then justify one choice.
48–58 min	**Baseline diagnostic (p.6)**	10 quick questions. No marks pressure — it tells you what they already know.
58–60 min	**Exit ticket (p.8)**	One thing they learned, one thing they want to run a business to find out.

Learning outcomes

- Explain what an entrepreneur does and the kinds of risk they take on.
- Tell the difference between revenue and profit, and why a growing business can still make little profit.
- Identify the stakeholders affected by a business decision and whose interests pull in different directions.

Spec links

A board-neutral course opener. AQA GCSE 8132 §3.1.1 "The purpose and nature of businesses" (incl. entrepreneurs, risk and reward) · Edexcel GCSE 1BS0 Theme 1, 1.1 "Enterprise and entrepreneurship" (incl. 1.1.2 risk and reward) · Cambridge IGCSE 0450 §1.3 "Enterprise, business growth and size".

Differentiation

Support: let pairs tackle the baseline together, and hand out the key terms (p.4) before the Do-Now so reading is lighter. **Stretch:** ask stronger students to bring their own failed-business example to the founder task and argue the outside reason it failed — not a missing trait.

Only got 30 minutes?

Run the Do-Now (8 min), then the key terms and the M&S case as a teacher-led talk-through (12 min), then use what's left for the hook discussion. Set the baseline diagnostic as the first homework and read it before lesson two. You keep the hook and still get the diagnostic data.

You'll need: *this print-out (one per student is ideal, one per pair works). No slides, logins, or board work required. If you only have 40 minutes, drop the Founder match task.*

Do-Now — a 19-year-old and a pile of gym vests

Read this on your own. You have five minutes. Then answer the three questions before you talk to anyone.

Gymshark

In 2012, Ben Francis was 19, delivering pizzas and studying in Birmingham. He started screen-printing gym wear and selling it online. He couldn't afford big-name sponsorships, so he sent free clothing to fitness personalities on social media and let them do the talking.

Gymshark now sells in around 230 countries and turned over roughly £646 million in its 2025 financial year. In 2020, the investment firm General Atlantic bought about a 20% stake in a deal that valued the company at around £1.45 billion. Francis kept control.

But in that same 2025 financial year, only about £7m was left as pre-tax profit — the business keeps pouring money back into growth rather than banking it.

Answer on your own first

1. Name two things Ben Francis risked by starting Gymshark instead of finishing his studies and keeping the pizza job.

2. He had almost no marketing budget. What did he do instead, and why might that have worked better than paying for adverts?

3. The company takes in £646m from sales but keeps only about £7m as profit. Is that a problem? Give one reason it might be fine, and one reason it might worry the owner.

Pair up (3 min): *swap answers to Q3. You almost certainly disagree on whether low profit is a problem. That argument is the whole of this course in miniature — hold onto it.*

Finished early?

Gymshark sent free clothing to fitness personalities instead of buying adverts. Write down one other business you follow online because of a person, not an advert — and one line on why that person makes you trust the brand more than an advert would.

Core — risk, reward, and who carries it

Five terms you'll use every week on this course. Write the definition in your own words next to each.

Term	What it means	In one line
Entrepreneur	Someone who spots an opportunity and takes a financial risk to turn it into a business.	Ben Francis.
Revenue	The total money a business takes in from sales before any costs are taken off.	Gymshark's ~£646m.
Profit	What's left after you subtract costs from revenue.	Gymshark's ~£7m (before tax).
Risk	The chance that a decision loses money or fails — the price of a possible reward.	Quitting a steady job.
Stakeholder	Any person or group affected by what a business does.	Staff, customers, owners.

The risk nobody chose — M&S, 2025

In 2025 Marks & Spencer was hit by a major cyber-attack. Online ordering was suspended for weeks, shelves had gaps, and the company estimated the hit to its operating profit at around £300 million.

Nobody at M&S chose to take this risk — but they carried it anyway. That's the point: risk in business isn't only the risk an entrepreneur signs up for. It arrives uninvited too — and on this course that counts as an **external influence**: something outside the business's control that still hits it hard.

Discuss as a class

- List four stakeholders affected by the M&S attack. For each, say in a few words how they were hit.
- An owner takes risk on purpose, hoping for a reward. M&S's owners took a £300m hit they never chose. Is that fair? Should anyone be able to limit it?
- Would you spend £50m a year on cyber-security to maybe prevent a £300m loss that might never happen? Defend your answer — there's no clean right answer, and that's deliberate.

Where you'll meet this again

Entrepreneur, risk and reward — the start of the course, and the lens for every "should they do it?" question. **Revenue and profit** — the finance topic, where you'll calculate both. **Stakeholders** — every decision question asks who wins and who loses. **External influences** — a whole topic on things a business can't control: technology, the economy, the law.

Pair task — what makes an entrepreneur?

Below are six traits people often link to entrepreneurs, and four real UK businesses. Work in pairs.

The traits

- Spots a gap others missed
- Comfortable with risk — happy to bet on an unknown outcome
- Resilient — keeps going after setbacks
- Resourceful — gets a lot from very little
- Long-term — will sacrifice profit now for growth later
- Reads the customer — understands what people actually want

Business	One real fact to work from
Gymshark	Built a global brand from nothing, using free product for fitness influencers instead of a marketing budget.
Greggs	Turned a bakery into ~2,600 UK shops; pushed into hot food and after-4pm opening to find new sales.
Aldi	Grew to ~45,000 UK staff by stripping out cost and range to keep prices low.
A failed business (your example)	Pick one you know of — a shop, app, or brand near you that didn't make it.

Your task

1. Match at least two traits to each of the three real businesses. A trait can be used more than once.

2. Pick the one trait you think matters most for surviving the first year, and write two sentences defending it. Be ready to disagree with the pair next to you.

3. **Stretch:** most businesses don't fail because the founder lacked a trait. Suggest one outside reason a good entrepreneur can still fail (think money, timing, competition).

Say it like a business student

Use these stems when you defend your choice: *"The trait that matters most is … because without it a new business would …"* · *"Gymshark shows this when …"* · *"I disagree, because a founder can have that trait and still fail if …"*

Baseline diagnostic — 10 quick questions

This isn't a test. It tells your teacher what you already know so the course starts in the right place. Answer in one line each. Guess if you're not sure.

1. What is the difference between revenue and profit?

2. Give one risk someone takes when they start a business.

3. Name two different stakeholders of a supermarket.

4. A coffee costs £1.10 to make and sells for £3.20. What is the profit per cup?

5. What does it mean to say a business has "gone bust"?

6. Give one reason a business might choose to grow more slowly.

7. What is the difference between a good and a service? Give an example of each.

8. Why might two people look at the same business decision and completely disagree?

9. Name a UK business you think is run well, and say why in one line.

10. Finish the sentence: "The main reason businesses exist is to…"

Baseline — answer guidance (teacher)

Use these to gauge starting points, not to mark harshly. Q4 is the only one with a single right answer.

Q	What you're looking for
1	Revenue = all money from sales; profit = what's left after costs. Many will blur the two — worth catching early.
2	Losing savings, debt, job security, time, reputation. Accept any genuine downside.
3	Any two of: customers, staff, owners, suppliers, local community, government.
4	£3.20 – £1.10 = £2.10 per cup. Note who reaches for a calculator vs sees it instantly.
5	The business can't pay what it owes and has to stop trading. Accept the gist.
6	Keep control, protect quality, avoid borrowing, manage cash, owner's choice. Any reasoned answer.
7	Good = physical (trainers); service = a thing done for you (a haircut). Mixed answers are fine to discuss.
8	Different stakeholders, different aims, different attitude to risk. This is the seed of evaluation — flag it.
9	Looking for any reason beyond "it's big" — value, service, treatment of staff, a clever decision.
10	There's no single answer. "Make a profit", "meet a need", "serve customers" all open good debate.

Quick read of the room: *if most students nail Q1 and Q4, you can move faster through the early finance basics. If Q8 produces blank looks, build in more "why do people disagree" work before you reach the longer exam answers — that's the skill the top grades are built on.*

Discussion pointers — M&S (page 4)

• **Stakeholders hit:** customers (couldn't order online, gaps on shelves), staff (disruption and pressure), owners (~£300m profit hit, share price fell), suppliers (orders and payments disrupted).

• **"Is it fair?"** No single answer — draw out that owners accept risk for reward, but a cyber-attack is hard to foresee. Good answers weigh responsibility against bad luck.

• **The £50m question:** reward the reasoning, not the side. The strong move is to compare the cost (and what else £50m could buy) against the size and the likelihood of the loss.

Founder match — suggested links (page 5)

Gymshark — resourceful, reads the customer, long-term. **Greggs** — reads the customer, resilient, spots a gap (hot food, after-4pm). **Aldi** — resourceful, comfortable with risk (price competition), long-term. Accept any trait a pair can defend — the justification matters more than the match.

After the lesson — what to do with the baseline

Skim the scripts in one pass and sort into three piles: **secure** (Q1 + Q4 right, sensible Q8), **middle**, and **watch** (blurred revenue/profit or blank Q8). Use the piles to set your pairs for the next few lessons — one secure student per pair beats setting by rows. Keep the scripts: showing students their own day-one answers at the end of Year 10 is the cheapest motivation you'll ever buy.

Plenary & exit ticket

Exit ticket — hand in on the way out

• One thing you understand now that you didn't at the start of the lesson.

• One thing you'd want to find out by actually running a business, not just reading about one.

What's coming on this course

The first weeks are about exactly what we did today — what businesses are for, entrepreneurs, and the risks of starting up. From there you'll look at the outside influences on a business, then how businesses are run day to day: operations, people, marketing and finance. Keep today's Gymshark argument in mind: almost every longer exam question on this course has two defensible answers.

Homework idea (10 minutes)

Find one UK business in the news this week. Write three lines: what happened, one stakeholder it affects, and whether the business chose the risk or the risk arrived uninvited. First retrieval of today's three big ideas — and it builds the news habit early, which pays off all course.

Want them to actually run a business?

This pack came from **The Business School** — a browser-based classroom simulation where students run a company in teams: set prices, hire staff, take out loans, file VAT and negotiate deals over a single 60-minute session. Up to 5 teams and 30 students. They join with a PIN, you watch a live dashboard, and it grades itself at the end. No installs.

The autumn pilot cohort is full — you can join the waitlist for the next round at **thebusiness.school**. No pressure — this lesson pack is yours to keep and share either way.

Company figures from publicly reported sources (Companies House filings and reputable press, 2024–2025): Gymshark FY25 revenue ~£646m / pre-tax profit ~£7m / 2020 ~20% stake at ~£1.45bn valuation; M&S 2025 cyber-attack ~£300m operating-profit impact; Greggs ~2,600 UK shops; Aldi ~45,000 UK staff.